ALAMY



Kolukkumalai Tea Estate

For the best hot cuppa

Perched at an altitude of 7,900 feet (2,408 metres), Kolukkumalai is the highest tea plantation in the world. Geographically in Tamil Nadu but located close to Munnar (Kerala), this estate is known for its panoramic views of the Western Ghats. The tea plants grow slower due to the high altitude, resulting in better quality tea. The journey to Kolukkumalai itself is an adventure, involving a bumpy ride through rugged terrain. Once there, embark on a tour of the tea factory that dates back to the 1920s. It still uses the orthodox method to process tea, which includes hand-plucking the tea leaves (apparently maintains the integrity of the leaves). Sit back, sip a freshly brewed cup while gazing at the mist-covered peaks....



Chikmagalur

For the ultimate coffee immersion

Known as the birthplace of coffee in India, Chikmagalur is heaven for caffeine lovers. In the 17th century, Baba Budan supposedly smuggled coffee seeds from Yemen and planted them on the hills around Chikmagalur. Today, this region has large coffee estates that grow some of the best Arabica and Robusta beans. Take a deep dive into the world of coffee with a plantation tour and understand the process of coffee cultivation from bean to cup. Many estates also offer homestays where you wake up to the aroma of freshly brewed coffee. If you seek adventure, nearby peaks like Baba Budangiri and Mullayanagiri offer excellent trekking opportunities.



Parambikulam Tiger Reserve

For the best offbeat wildlife experience

Escape the usual tourist circuit in Kerala to uncover this hidden gem. A protected biodiversity hotspot, the Parambikulam sanctuary is located in Palakkad district. What makes Parambikulam unique is its eco-tourism initiatives, including guided safaris, bamboo rafting and tribal village stays. Many indigenous tribes still live within the reserve, and the Tribal Heritage Centre is a good place to learn more about their unique way of life and cultural heritage. You can also trek to the world's oldest teak tree, Kannimara, believed to be over 450 years old.



Kodaikanal

For its colonial era charm

Fondly called the 'Princess of Hills', Kodaikanal is steeped in colonial history. Established by British missionaries in the 19th century, the town is dotted with old churches, colonial style cottages and scenic viewpoints. Its centrepiece is the star-shaped Kodai Lake, where you can enjoy boat rides or go cycling around its perimeter. Other attractions include Coaker's Walk, an old British-built pathway offering stunning valley views, and Bryant Park, a lovely botanical garden with rare flora. Some of the viewpoints worth driving to include Upper Lake View for a bird's-eye view of Kodai Lake, Guna Cave made famous by the 1991 Kamal Haasan-starrer *Guna* (the cave itself is closed but the views are spectacular) and Pillar Rocks that looks out over three vertical boulders dramatically rising more than 400 feet.